PRODUCT DESIGN PORTFOLIO · 2026

Dharmarao Balaga

Senior / Principal Product Designer · UX Strategy · AI-Enabled Product Design



From visual storytelling to product strategy — designing for people since 2001.

M.Des, IIT Bombay
Animation & Film

Head of Product Design
7 yrs · Openplay (Nazara)

Founder
D'SARAS Design Studio

dharmaraobalaga.github.io/portfolio

linkedin.com/in/dharmarao-balaga-7a67937

dharmaraobalaga@gmail.com

Hyderabad, India

WHY I'M DIFFERENT

Four chapters that make one product designer

01

Storyteller

2001 – 2014

M.Des in Animation & Film from IIT Bombay; 13 years as illustrator, animator and team lead.

I design flows the way I once paced films: sequence, clarity, emotion.

02

Design leader

2014 – 2025

Design Manager at Adeon, then 7 years as Head of Product Design at Openplay (Nazara Group).

Built and mentored a multidisciplinary team and set design standards across products.

03

Product shipper

2018 · 2026

Classic Rummy shipped on Android & iOS in 2018; TWAM went live on Google Play in June 2026.

End-to-end ownership: research, IA, interaction, UI, design system, handoff.

04

AI practitioner

2025 – today

Founder of D'SARAS Design Studio, running an AI-assisted design practice.

AI widens the exploration. The problem framing and final decisions stay mine.

The result: a designer who connects user needs, business goals and technology — and can show the reasoning behind every screen.

MY PROFESSIONAL JOURNEY

From visual storytelling to product innovation

2001 – 2014

Foundations

Illustrator → Graphic Designer → Animator → Team Lead

Color Chips · Globarena · Polygon Studios · The Boston Group · Helix · Esya · Cordys

Visual communication · Animation

2014 – 2018

Design Manager / Creative Head

Adeon Media Technologies

UX/UI and creative direction for enterprise & consumer web and mobile, incl. client brand Frodoe

UX/UI · Team leadership

2018 – 2025

Head of Product Design

Openplay Technologies (Nazara Games)

Led Classic Rummy from Flash to native mobile; design standards & systems; built and mentored the team

Product strategy · Design systems

2025 – today

Founder & Principal Product Designer

D'SARAS Design Studio

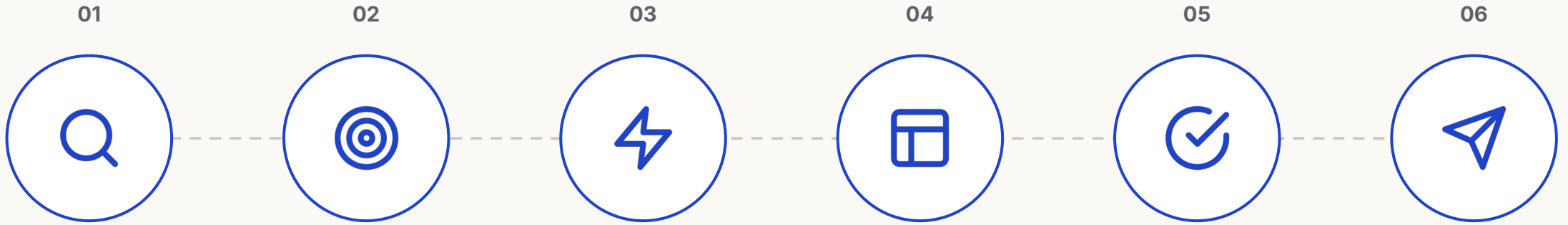
Product design consulting, TWAM, the DSDS design system, DesignAcharya, AI-assisted workflows

AI-enabled product design

Education **Master of Design (M.Des), Animation & Film — IIT Bombay** · Bachelor of Fine Arts, Applied Arts — JNAFAU, Hyderabad

HOW I WORK

One approach, proven on real products



01	02	03	04	05	06
Discover	**Define**	**Ideate**	**Design**	**Validate**	**Deliver**
Player interviews, 2 surveys and a 5-app competitive audit (Classic Rummy)	Two personas became two doors into one lobby; “How might we…” framing	Dial picker vs. real table list; 3 AI placements compared (ResolveAI)	IA, flows, UI kit and tokens; 20+ TWAM screens on one design system	Post-MVP usability study with task tests; WCAG contrast checks	Dev handoff and optimised assets; TWAM live on Google Play

Every decision is weighed on three axes: **User value × Business value × Technical feasibility**

FEATURED CASE STUDY 01 · OPENPLAY TECHNOLOGIES (NAZARA GROUP)

Rebuilding Classic Rummy for a mobile-first India

THE PROBLEM

In 2018 Chrome began phasing out Flash, and Classic Rummy's entire web platform was heading for obsolescence — putting accessibility, retention and device compatibility at risk at once.

> *How might we design an intuitive, engaging rummy app that works for both novice and expert players, and keeps gameplay seamless across devices?*

My role	Product design lead · end-to-end UX/UI ownership
Timeline	Feb – May 2018 · ~12 weeks
Platforms	Native Android, iOS and web
Worked with	Product, Engineering and QA
Status	Shipped 2018 · discontinued after India's 2025 ban on online money games



Players wanted less friction and more trust

Interviews with existing Flash players

Qualitative + quantitative surveys

Audit of 5 leading Indian rummy apps

CASUAL LEARNER

Vineet, 28 · Pune

"Will I be able to play this without prior experience? Is it safe to put my money here?"

Needs a pressure-free place to learn

→ Guided onboarding and a separate Practice door

COMPETITIVE REGULAR

Rajesh, 55 · Hyderabad

"I need smooth gameplay with no interruptions. Are my winnings secure?"

Needs speed and transparent prizes

→ One-tap competitive modes and live leaderboards

PLAYER SURVEY

85% preferred playing on a smartphone

85% found interactive tutorials helpful for learning rules

75% said tournaments & leaderboards are essential

The tension between relaxed learning and fast, high-stakes competition shaped almost every layout decision.

Five calls that shaped the product

1. **Two doors from one lobby**

   Practice for learners; Cash and Tournaments for regulars — both one tap from Home.

2. **Landscape to play, portrait for money**

   A 13-card hand needs width; forms read better upright. Switches only at flow boundaries.

3. **Real tables instead of a dial picker**

   Regulars choose by players, entry fee and status — filters removed a guess-then-wait step.

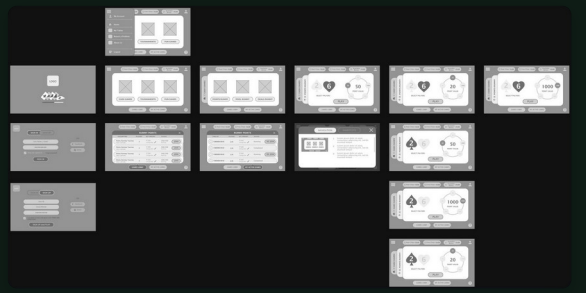
4. **Trust on the very first screen**

   Splash leads with withdrawals, secure payments, real players and RNG certification.

5. **Retention through progress, not pop-ups**

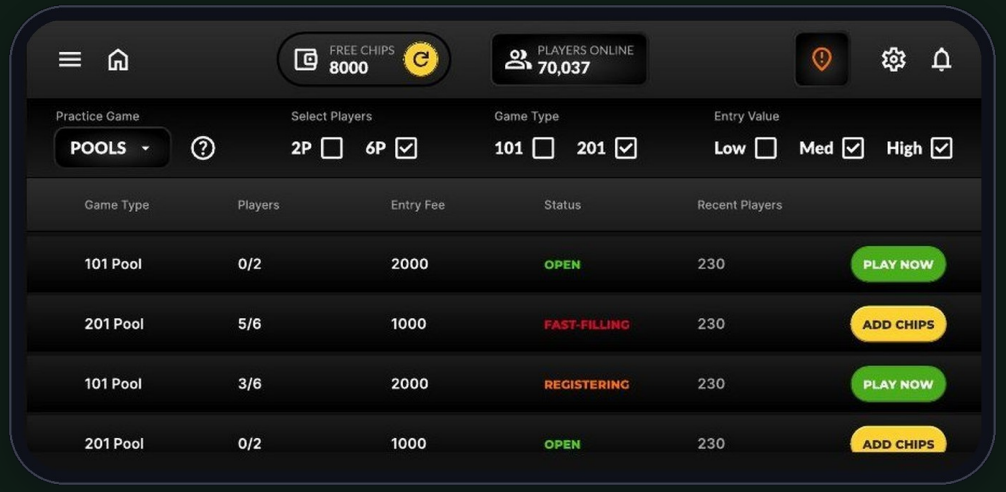
   A 7-day challenge, live leaderboards and table timers give reasons to return.

DECISION 3 — BEFORE



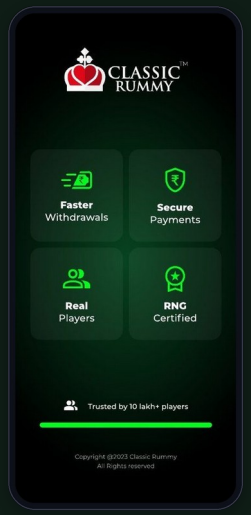
Early low-fi concepts used a playful dial to pick players and point value — but it hid the actual tables.

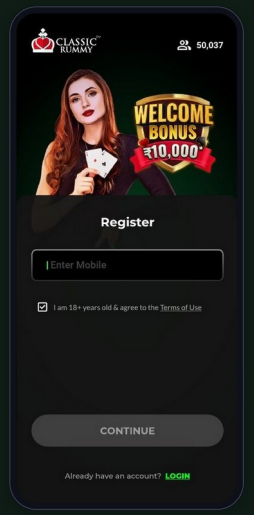
AFTER — SHIPPED



CLASSIC RUMMY · FINAL EXPERIENCE

Familiar felt-table green, modern clarity

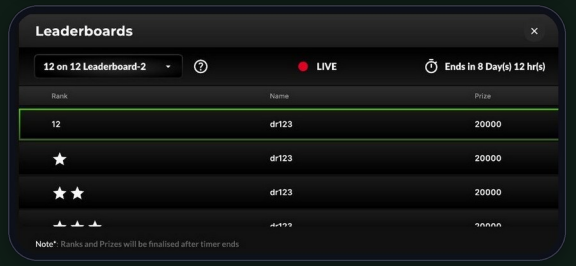












TESTED · POST-MVP

Usability study

Task-based tests and interviews, measuring completion rate and time-on-task.

ITERATED

Fixed what we found

Unclear scoring and missed challenges → in-context scoring help; challenges promoted on Home.

2026 PROPOSAL · NOT SHIPPED

The Practice door becomes the product

Rebuild it as a free-to-play social skill game with contextual rule hints.

BUSINESS IMPACT

Company results my work contributed to

2× **ROI**

Contributed to doubling ROI during the COVID-19 period

2× **Engagement**

Contributed to achieving 2x user engagement

Retention

Supported retention through UX and product improvements

Performance

Collaborated on game performance and loading speed

Early exploration: *AI-driven matchmaking was being explored — not shipped.*

FEATURED CASE STUDY 02 · ONLYTWAM · D'SARAS DESIGN STUDIO

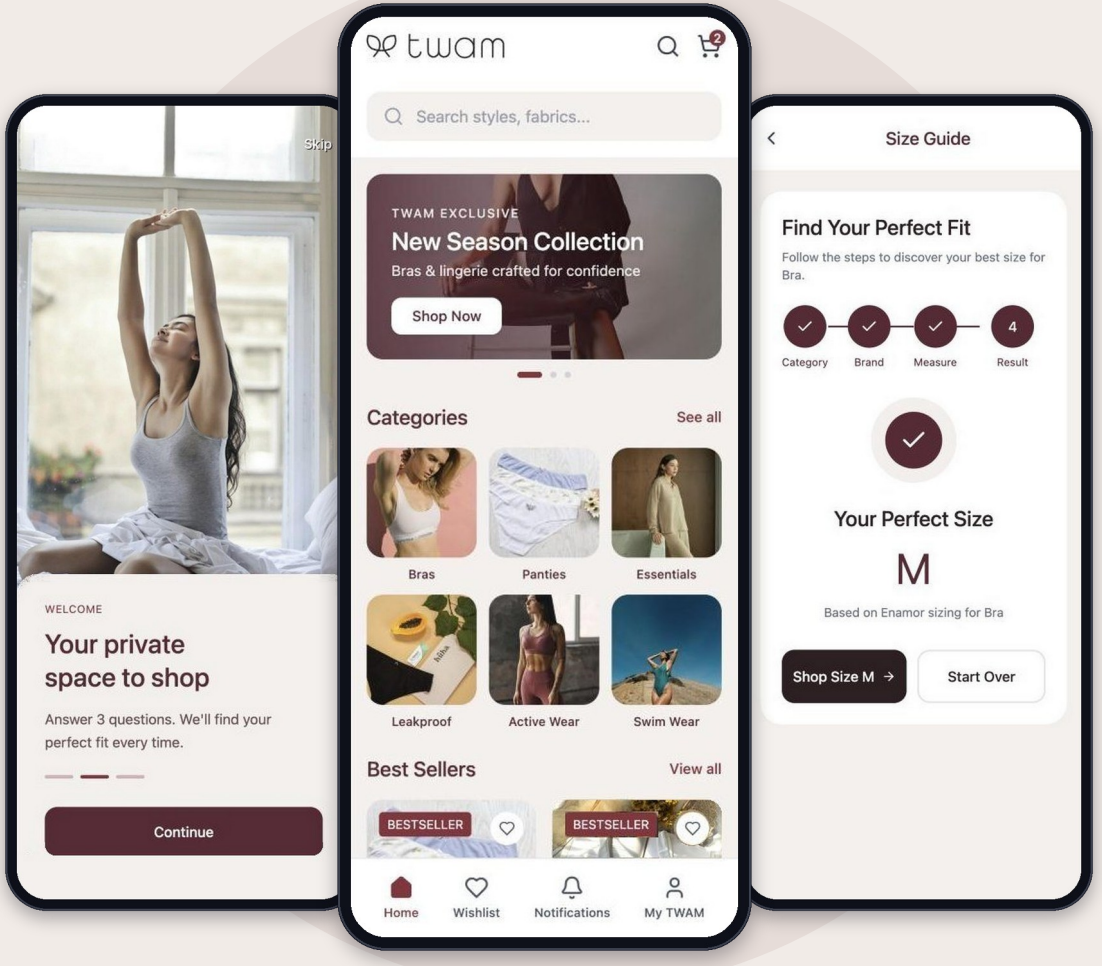
TWAM: shopping designed around privacy and fit

THE PROBLEM

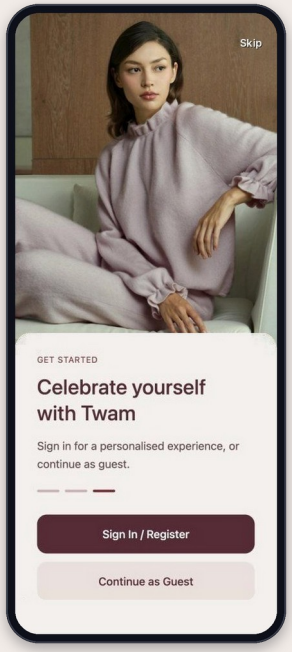
A woman shopping for innerwear on her phone has two worries before price comes up: **will it fit, and who will see what I bought?** Most shopping apps answer neither — and add pop-ups, countdowns and forced sign-up.

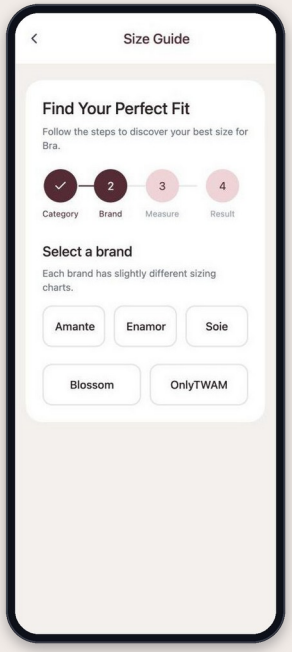
How might we help her find her size and buy privately, without making her sign up, measure herself or wade through promotions first?

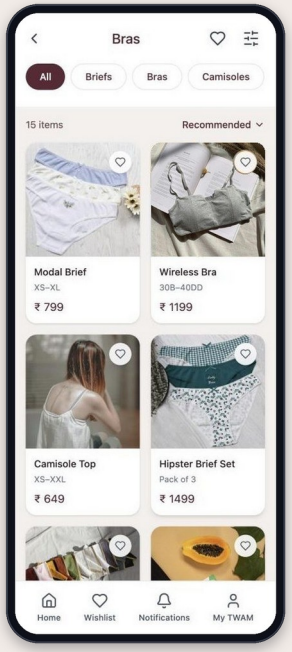
My role	Product designer, end to end: strategy, UX, UI, prototype
Timeline	April – June 2026
Tools	Claude · Figma Make (135 versions) · Figma
Status	**Shipped · live on Google Play since 20 June 2026**

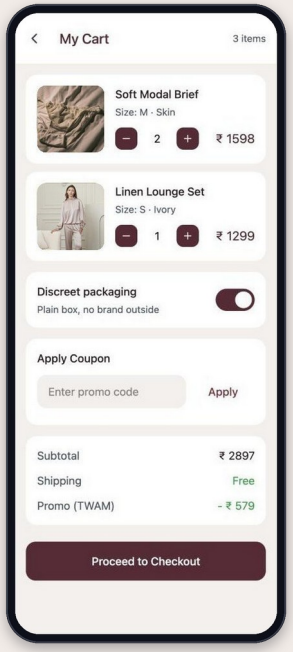


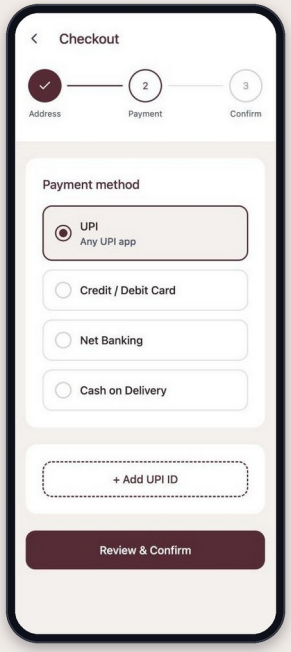
Five calls, each with a cost I chose to accept











Guest browsing

Skip on every onboarding step; “Continue as Guest”.

Cost: personalisation starts later.

Fit from a known size

Pick a brand she wears and her size there — no tape measure.

Cost: only as good as brand size data.

Size range on cards

“XS–XL” or “30B–40DD” under each name.

Cost: ratings dropped from listing cards.

Discreet by default

“Plain box, no brand outside” — a cart toggle, on by default.

Cost: gives up a branded unboxing.

UPI first, COD kept

Three-step checkout opens on UPI; cash on delivery stays.

Cost: more cancellations and returns.

From the first brief to version 135

	APRIL BRIEF	VERSION 135 · SHIPPED
Colour	Bright red #D72229 on buttons and headings	**Deep burgundy #562C36 — quieter, more premium**
Surfaces	Warm ivory #FAF5F0 with blush and rose	**Soft greige #F4F0ED, white cards, blush chips**
Imagery	Flat lays and textures only, no models	**Real people across skin tones and body types**
Navigation	5 tabs, including a separate Menu	**4 tabs; categories folded into Home and Search**
Fit help	Step-by-step body measurement	**Start from a brand and size she already wears**

Honest status: personas and insights came from desk research and are labelled hypotheses; launch metrics are not published.

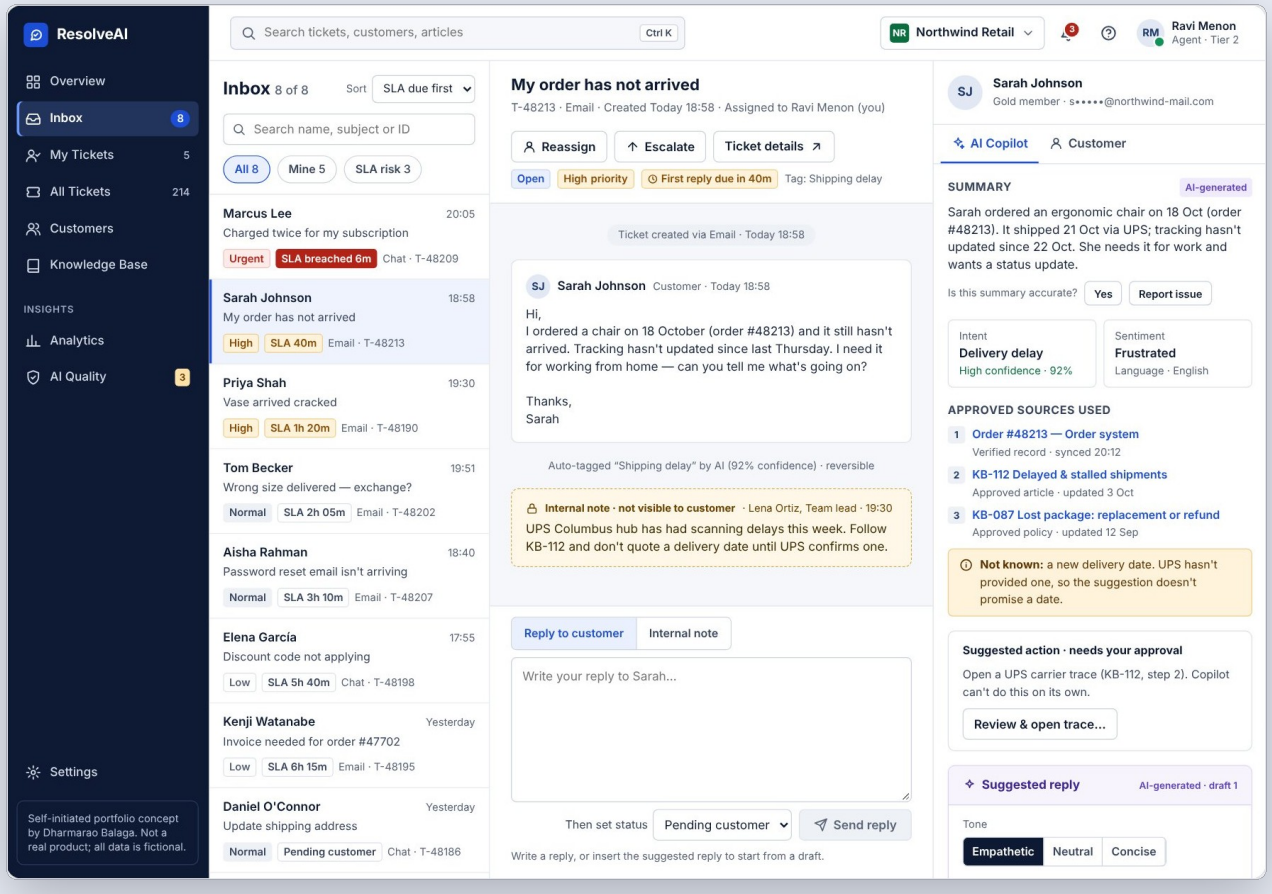
MY AI-ASSISTED BUILD

1. **Brief**
   Experience principles: calm, private, trust-first
2. **Claude**
   Written briefs became early code prototypes
3. **Figma Make**
   Refined over 135 saved versions
4. **Self-audit**
   Every flow reviewed before launch

"The tools generated; I decided what stayed."

SUPPORTING CASE STUDY · SELF-INITIATED CONCEPT (2026) · NOT A SHIPPED PRODUCT

ResolveAI: AI that support agents can overrule



Built with Microsoft HAX guidelines, Google PAIR and WCAG 2.2 · every text pair ≥ 5.25:1 contrast

WHERE SHOULD THE AI LIVE?

A	**Auto-draft in the composer**	Fastest — but invites over-trust
B	**Side panel, explicit "Insert & edit"**	**Chosen: evidence beside the draft**
C	**Separate AI view**	Hides the thread while drafting

GUARDRAILS I DESIGNED

Cite or remove: every sentence carries a source; unsupported claims are struck through.

Review gate: Send stays disabled until an AI-assisted reply is reviewed.

Failure as a state: thin data or an outage never blocks the inbox.

All data is fictional. Hypotheses are defined and a test plan with 5–6 support agents is written — not yet run.

AI-POWERED PRODUCT DESIGN

AI accelerates my design. Judgement stays human.

01

Research synthesis

ChatGPT · Claude · Gemini

Cluster survey answers, draft affinity groups — then verify against raw quotes

02

Ideation & UX writing

Claude · ChatGPT · Gemini

Generate and compare more concepts before polishing any one

03

Rapid prototyping

Figma Make · Figma AI · Google Stitch

Shorten the path from a written brief to a working prototype

04

Visual & motion

Midjourney · Leonardo AI · Runway ML

Visual exploration, concept art and motion studies

Human gate at every step: I define the problem, evaluate trade-offs, ensure usability and make the final decision.

At Openplay

Introduced AI-assisted research and design workflows for the team.

At D'SARAS

Built a studio workflow with ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Figma Make and Stitch, used across client work.

In TWAM

Briefs → Claude prototypes → 135 Figma Make versions → my self-audit.

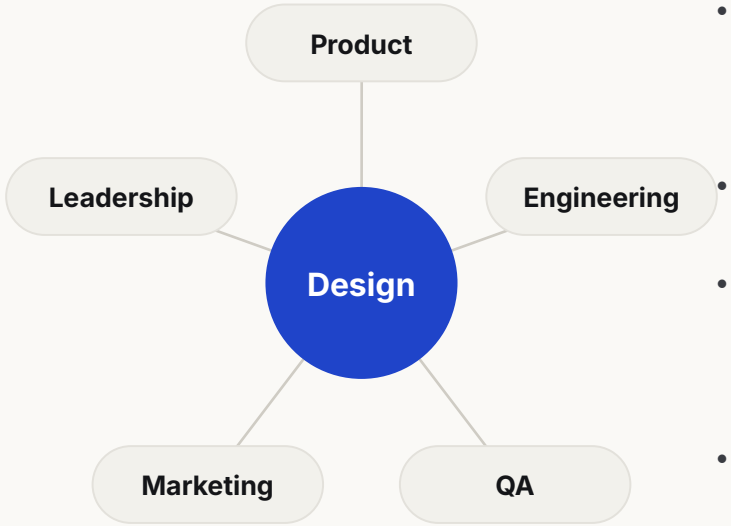
In ResolveAI

I wrote the brief and guardrail spec; AI produced screens; I reviewed every state against the spec.

LEADERSHIP & STUDIO

Leading design teams — and my own studio

HEAD OF PRODUCT DESIGN · OPENPLAY · 2018–2025



- Owned product design strategy and execution across gaming and digital products for 7 years
- Built, managed and mentored a multidisciplinary design team
- Set design standards and scalable design systems with Product, Engineering, Marketing and Leadership
- Used research and product insight to prioritise improvements

FOUNDER · D'SARAS DESIGN STUDIO · SINCE FEB 2025

A multi-wing studio: "Build better products. Grow faster. Train smarter."

Design

UX/UI, product design, mobile apps, design systems

Growth

Performance, SEO, CRO and funnels built on UX thinking

Academy

DesignAcharya — AI-era, Telugu–English design programme

Stories

2D animation, brand films and culturally rooted stories

Also built: the DSDS design system (tokens, wing themes, responsive patterns) and the studio's responsive website — dsaras.com.

WHAT I BRING TO YOUR TEAM

Let’s build products people understand and trust

Product thinking

Framing problems around users and business goals

End-to-end craft

Research, IA, interaction, UI, systems and handoff

Design leadership

7 years leading and mentoring a product design team

Practical AI

Faster exploration, with human judgement in charge

Open to Senior / Principal Product Designer, Product Design Lead and Design Manager roles — hybrid, onsite or remote.



Dharmarao Balaga

Senior / Principal Product Designer

dharmaraobalaga@gmail.com

+91 97044 32414

dharmaraobalaga.github.io/portfolio

linkedin.com/in/dharmarao-balaga-7a67937

behance.net/dharmaportfolio

Hyderabad, India